DEFENCE JOURNEY

NDA English Notes

Grammar, vocabulary and comprehension for the NDA English section

NDA | ENGLISH

The English section of NDA Paper 2 (General Ability Test) carries **200 marks** (50 questions, 4 marks each, 1/3 negative marking). It tests grammar, vocabulary and comprehension. Grammar rules give the most dependable marks, so master them first.

Topic	Typical questions	How to prepare
Spotting errors / Sentence improvement	8 to 12	Learn the grammar rules below
Synonyms and Antonyms	6 to 8	Learn 10 new words daily
Ordering of words / sentences	5 to 8	Practise finding the opening and closing sentence
Fill in the blanks (prepositions, articles, tenses)	6 to 8	Revise rules and phrasal verbs
Idioms and phrases, One-word substitution	4 to 6	Revise the lists in these notes
Comprehension passages	8 to 12	Read an editorial daily

1. Parts of Speech

Part	Job	Examples
Noun	Names a person, place, thing or idea	Ravi, Delhi, honesty
Pronoun	Replaces a noun	he, they, who, myself
Adjective	Describes a noun	brave soldier, three books
Verb	Shows action or state	run, is, have
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or adverb	runs quickly, very tall
Preposition	Shows relation to a noun	in, on, at, by, with
Conjunction	Joins words or clauses	and, but, because, although
Interjection	Expresses sudden feeling	Alas! Hurrah!

2. Subject-Verb Agreement

- A singular subject takes a singular verb: *The boy **plays***. A plural subject takes a plural verb: *The boys **play***.
- Subjects joined by **and** take a plural verb: *Ram and Shyam **are** friends*. Exception: when both words name one person or thing, use a singular verb: *Bread and butter **is** my breakfast*.

- With **either…or, neither…nor**, the verb agrees with the subject **nearest** to it: *Neither the teacher nor the students **were** present*.
- **Each, every, either, neither, one of, anyone, everyone, nobody** take a singular verb: *Each of the boys **has** a book*.
- Words joined by **with, along with, as well as, together with** do not change the verb: *The captain, along with his men, **is** ready*.
- Collective nouns (team, class, army) take a singular verb when seen as one unit: *The army **is** strong*.
- Nouns that look plural but are singular: *news, mathematics, physics, politics*. Plural only: *scissors, trousers, spectacles*.
- **A number of** takes a plural verb. **The number of** takes a singular verb.

3. Tenses

Tense	Simple	Continuous	Perfect
Present	He writes	He is writing	He has written
Past	He wrote	He was writing	He had written
Future	He will write	He will be writing	He will have written

- Use the **simple present** for general truths: *The sun rises in the east*.
- **Since** is used with a point in time (since 2020). **For** is used with a period (for five years). Both go with the present perfect: *He has lived here since 2015*.
- In an if-clause, do not use *will*: *If it rains, I will stay home* (not “if it will rain”).
- After **wish** or **as if** about an unreal situation use *were*: *I wish I were a pilot*.
- Words such as **yesterday, ago, last year** need the past tense. **Already, yet, just, ever, never** usually go with the present perfect.

4. Articles and Determiners

- Use **a** before a consonant *sound* and **an** before a vowel *sound*: *a university, an hour, an MBA, a one-rupee note*.
- Use **the** for something specific or unique: *the Sun, the Himalayas, the Ganga, the President*.
- No article before names of languages, meals, games and most countries: *He plays cricket. We had lunch.*
- **Few** and **many** are for countable nouns. **Little** and **much** are for uncountable nouns.
- **A few** means some (positive). **Few** means hardly any (negative). The same applies to **a little / little**.
- **Less** goes with uncountable nouns (less water), **fewer** with countable nouns (fewer students).

5. Prepositions

Use	Rule	Example
Time	**at** a point, **on** a day or date, **in** a month, year or period	at 5 pm, on Monday, in June
Place	**at** a point, **in** an enclosed area, **on** a surface	at the gate, in the room, on the table
Between / Among	**between** two, **among** three or more	between you and me, among friends
Since / For	point of time / duration	since 2010, for ten years
By / With	**by** the doer or means, **with** the instrument	written by him, cut with a knife

Words followed by fixed prepositions

Word + preposition	Word + preposition	Word + preposition
abide **by**	accuse **of**	adhere **to**
afraid **of**	agree **to** (a plan) / **with** (a person)	angry **with** (a person) / **at** (a thing)
aware **of**	capable **of**	congratulate **on**
consist **of**	depend **on**	different **from**
divide **into**	eager **for**	good **at**
insist **on**	interested **in**	jealous **of**
prefer **to**	proud **of**	participate **in**
reply **to**	succeed **in**	superior **to**
suffer **from**	wait **for**	warn **against**

6. Pronouns and Common Errors

- Use the **subject form** as the subject (I, he, she, we, they) and the **object form** as the object (me, him, her, us, them). *Between you and **me*** (not “I”).
- **Who** is for the subject, **whom** for the object: *The man whom I met*.
- Use **myself, himself** only when it refers back to the subject: *He hurt himself*.
- The adjective **comparative** compares two (taller than), the **superlative** compares more than two (the tallest).
- Never use a double comparative: *more better*, *most unkindest* are wrong.
- Some adjectives are already absolute and cannot be compared: *perfect, unique, round, complete*.
- Words like **senior, junior, superior, inferior, prefer** take **to** instead of *than*: *He is senior to me*.
- **Rise** (no object), **raise** (needs an object); **lie** (rest), **lay** (put down).
- **Scarcely / hardly … when** and **no sooner … than**: *No sooner had he arrived than it began to rain*.

7. Voice, Narration and Conditionals

- **Active to Passive:** the object becomes the subject, the verb becomes (be + past participle), and the old subject follows *by*. *She wrote a letter → A letter was written by her.*
- **Direct to Indirect speech:** change the tense one step back, and change pronouns and time words (*now → then, today → that day, tomorrow → the next day, here → there*).
- *He said, "I am ill." → He said that he was ill.*
- **Conditionals:** Type 1 If + present, will + verb. Type 2 If + past, would + verb. Type 3 If + past perfect, would have + past participle.
- **Question tags:** a positive statement takes a negative tag and the other way round: *You are ready, aren't you? He doesn't know, does he?*

8. Vocabulary: Synonyms and Antonyms

Word	Synonym (similar)	Antonym (opposite)
Abundant	plentiful, ample	scarce, rare
Benevolent	kind, generous	malevolent, cruel
Candid	frank, honest	deceitful, secretive
Diligent	hardworking, industrious	lazy, careless
Eminent	famous, distinguished	unknown, obscure
Frugal	thrifty, economical	extravagant, wasteful
Gloomy	dismal, sad	cheerful, bright
Hostile	unfriendly, aggressive	friendly, amiable
Meticulous	careful, precise	careless, sloppy
Obstinate	stubborn, headstrong	flexible, yielding
Prudent	wise, cautious	reckless, foolish
Reluctant	unwilling, hesitant	eager, willing
Timid	shy, fearful	bold, daring
Vivid	bright, clear	dull, faint
Zealous	enthusiastic, passionate	indifferent, apathetic

TIP: Learn words in pairs (synonym and antonym together), and make one sentence with each new word. Revise 10 words every day.

9. One-Word Substitution

Meaning	Word	Meaning	Word
One who loves mankind	Philanthropist	A person who knows everything	Omniscient
One who hates mankind	Misanthrope	Government by the people	Democracy
Fear of closed spaces	Claustrophobia	Rule by one person	Autocracy
Study of birds	Ornithology	A place where bees are kept	Apiary
One who does not believe in God	Atheist	A speech by one actor alone	Monologue
Life story written by oneself	Autobiography	A list of books	Bibliography
That which cannot be avoided	Inevitable	Unable to be read	Illegible
Present everywhere	Omnipresent	That which cannot be believed	Incredible
A person who is new to a field	Novice	Murder of a king	Regicide

10. Idioms and Phrases

Idiom	Meaning	Idiom	Meaning
A blessing in disguise	a good thing that seemed bad at first	Break the ice	start a conversation
Burn the midnight oil	work or study late at night	Cut corners	do something the cheap or easy way
Beat around the bush	avoid the main point	Hit the nail on the head	say exactly the right thing
Once in a blue moon	very rarely	Piece of cake	very easy
Under the weather	feeling ill	Spill the beans	reveal a secret
Bite the bullet	face a difficult situation bravely	A white elephant	a costly and useless possession
Call it a day	stop working for the day	In the nick of time	just in time
Let the cat out of the bag	reveal a secret by mistake	To cry over spilt milk	regret what cannot be changed
Turn a blind eye	ignore on purpose	At the eleventh hour	at the last moment

11. Ordering of Sentences

- Find the **opening sentence**: it introduces the topic and does not start with words like *he, this, however*.
- Look for **link words**: *but, therefore, thus, also, then* usually do not start a paragraph.
- Pronouns (he, it, they) must come after the noun they refer to.
- Find the **concluding sentence**, which usually gives a result, summary or opinion.

- Arrange the remaining sentences in logical order of time or cause and effect.

12. Reading Comprehension Strategy

- Read the questions first, then read the passage once at a steady pace.
- Underline the main idea in the first and last lines of each paragraph.
- For vocabulary questions, use the sentence context rather than the word's usual meaning.
- Avoid options that use extreme words such as *always, never, only, all* unless the passage says so.
- Do not use outside knowledge. The answer must come from the passage.
- Read an English newspaper editorial every day (The Hindu or Indian Express) for 20 minutes.

Common Spelling Confusions

Pair	Difference
accept / except	accept = receive; except = apart from
affect / effect	affect = to influence (verb); effect = result (noun)
principal / principle	principal = head of a school; principle = rule
stationary / stationery	stationary = not moving; stationery = writing material
complement / compliment	complement = completes; compliment = praise
site / sight / cite	site = place; sight = vision; cite = quote
lose / loose	lose = misplace or fail to win; loose = not tight